

The Nations on Campus — sending, receiving and reaching

Delivered to the Fusion USA Learning Community. 28 May 2026. Christian Selvaratnam

The church in Antioch

God's mission to the nations moves in three directions: sending, receiving and reaching. Let's begin with the church at Antioch.

Acts 13: 'In the church at Antioch there were prophets and teachers: Barnabas, Simeon who was called Niger, Lucius of Cyrene, Manaen — a member of the court of Herod the ruler — and Saul.'

Look at who is in this room. Barnabas — a Jewish Levite from Cyprus, speaking Greek. Probably, the local leader because he's named first. Simeon, called Niger — probably an African man; his nickname, Niger, is Latin for 'the black one'. Lucius — from the Jewish diaspora of Cyrene, in what is now Libya. Manaen — raised in Herod's royal palace and even sharing his wet nurse, educated and formed by every privilege his world could offer. And Saul of Tarsus — Roman citizen, privileged education, Pharisee, tentmaker, and former persecutor of the Church.

So, a Levite, an African, a Libyan, an aristocrat, and a former persecutor. From three continents, speaking at least four languages, and with class differences so wide that in their society they would never have eaten at the same table. And yet, here in Acts 13 they are leading one of the most important churches in the early Christian world.

1. The gospel is personal *and* intercultural

Antioch is the church from which the gospel goes out to Europe. This is the team the Spirit gathers from the nations — and then sends back to them. Their diversity is not the background to the story. It is the story.

The gospel is two things at once. It is personal, and it is intercultural. We tend to be strong on the first and weak on the second.

Personal — yes. The gospel meets each of us individually where we are, in our own life, our own language, our own particularity. We are not asked to become someone else before Christ will have us.

The gospel is also intercultural. Paul says it most directly in Ephesians 2: Christ 'is our peace; in his flesh he has ... broken down the dividing wall, that is, the hostility between us.' He is speaking of the deepest hostility his local world knew — Jew and Gentile — and he is saying that the cross has done away with it.

Lesslie Newbigin, who gave forty years to mission in India before returning to England in the 1970s and discovering that the West itself was now a mission field, put it bluntly: the idea that we could ever distil out a pure gospel, unadulterated by cultural accretion, is an illusion.¹ The gospel always arrives in a culture, and it is always large enough to redeem the culture it arrives in. Antioch is the first church we can watch becoming genuinely mixed — and the first place the name 'Christian' attaches to a community that is no longer simply Jewish. It is not a Jewish church with Gentile guests. It is not a Greek church with a Jewish flavour. It is a new thing.

A gospel that is only individualistic is not yet the whole gospel. If our salvation and church do not, sooner or later, place us at the same table breaking bread with people who are not like us, then something is missing.

2. The nations have come to us

For two centuries the Church has read mission largely through one verse: Matthew 28, the Great Commission to 'Go and make disciples of all nations.' Since William Carey at the end of the eighteenth century, and through the great missionary movement that followed, this has been our key mission text — sending tens of thousands of women and men across the world, often at great personal cost, as missionaries.²

But in our lifetimes the geography has changed faster than the Church has caught up.

I live in the United Kingdom where today nearly one in five people were born somewhere else.³ In London, the figure is nearly double that.⁴ More than three hundred languages are spoken in the capital.⁵

In the last 50 years the nations have moved from 'over there', to 'right here'. The nations are now on our streets, and, we hope, in our pews. The missionary impulse that once sent us to the nations hasn't been removed; it's just been relocated. The nations are now in the city, and your city — and your campus — is now the global mission field.

This is a startling reversal for those of us trained to think of world mission as *going* and *sending*. We are now learning to think of it also as *receiving* and *welcoming*. The Gambian missiologist Lamin Sanneh, who taught at Yale, said that 'the original language of Christianity is translation'.⁶ Every time the gospel crosses a cultural border, it learns to speak a new language without losing what it is saying. That work used to happen on the ships carrying missionaries to the mission field. Now it happens at the school gate, in the doctor's surgery, in the queue at the supermarket, and in college ministry.

3. The public witness of an intercultural church

Which brings me to my last point, and to my own church.

I serve in an ordinary parish in York. In our congregation are two men. One is a recent convert — a wonderful man, full of new faith — who this past autumn was also tying St George's flags to the lampposts in our area. These flags are a sign of patriotism but are also a protest against immigration and racial diversity. The other man is a local-government officer whose work includes taking those same flags down.

Last Sunday I had the two of them side by side at the communion rail, receiving the same bread. The man who puts the flags up and the man who takes them down — kneeling together to be fed by the same Christ.

My question is whether we can learn to hold difference like this across the church, and to do it well. Not only my two flag men, but people born in different nations, people from different racial groups perhaps carrying long and sometimes unequal histories, people from different social classes, different political views and different neighbourhoods.

If this transformation is possible, we become an intercultural church — which I take to be the fruit of praying not only for personal salvation but the bringing-down of all that divides people, something made possible only through Christ's social salvation.

I am not sure we are there yet; I suspect it will take a generation. But this is the public witness an intercultural church carries: the sign of a unity that runs deeper than wealth, heritage or skin colour — something our society badly needs and does not know how to manufacture. Politics has few tools for reconciling communities at this depth; the gospel has one, and the local church is where it is put on show. Newbigin's claim was that the gospel has only one hermeneutic: a congregation that believes it and lives by it.⁷ What I want to add is that a congregation which holds together the differences of its neighbourhood makes that reading legible to people who will never open a Bible. A church that looks like the full range of its neighbourhood, eating the same bread on a Sunday morning, is a powerful witness to the power of Christ.

And the students we serve are at the heart of this. In many ways this unity may come more naturally to their generation than to ours, and the forming of it is best begun while they are still students — mobile, mixing, not yet settled into the habits of a homogeneous congregation.

So if the work takes a generation, our calling now is to prepare the ground: to invest in the students we reach today — across difference, heritage and social class — as the generation who will send, receive and reach in their turn, and who will both belong to and lead the intercultural churches of the future. Churches that show a divided society that Christ saves people — and pulls down the wall between them.

Questions

1. How diverse is your leadership team — and does it reflect where you're stuck, or where you want to be?
2. We're familiar with personal salvation. What is the 'social salvation' in which Christ breaks down the dividing walls (Ephesians 2:14) — and what changes when we take it as seriously as the personal?
3. How diverse is your local community, and has it changed recently? Now set that against the colleges you serve and the churches you belong to — where are the gaps?
4. What would it look like to invest in today's students as the intercultural church leaders the next generation needs — and how do we best serve and form them for that now?

Notes

¹ Lesslie Newbigin, *Foolishness to the Greeks: The Gospel and Western Culture* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1986).

² On Carey, the Victorian missionary movement, and its theological framing, see Brian Stanley, *The Bible and the Flag: Protestant Missions and British Imperialism in the Nineteenth and Twentieth Centuries* (Leicester: Apollos, 1990); and David Bosch, *Transforming Mission: Paradigm Shifts in Theology of Mission* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1991), esp. 339–45.

³ Centre for Policy Studies, analysis of revised ONS long-term international migration estimates, November 2025; ONS, *Long-term international migration, provisional: year ending June 2024*.

⁴ Office for National Statistics, Census 2021 data for Greater London; figures consistent with Migration Observatory, *London and its Boroughs: Census Profile*.

⁵ Philip Baker and Yasir Mohieldeen, 'The Languages of London's Schoolchildren', in *Multilingual Capital: The Languages of London's Schoolchildren and Their Relevance to Economic, Social and Educational Policies*, ed. Philip Baker and John Eversley (London: Battlebridge, 2000), 5–60. The survey covered some 896,700 pupils and recorded over 300 home languages. The figure comes from school returns, not the population census, which records far fewer: Census 2011 listed 90 languages for London. For an update on 2008 data, see John Eversley et al., *Language Capital: Mapping the Languages of London's Schoolchildren* (London: CILT, 2010).

⁶ Lamin Sanneh, *Translating the Message: The Missionary Impact on Culture* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1989), 116. Note that the exact wording quoted also circulates from Sanneh's *Whose Religion Is Christianity?* (2003).

⁷ Lesslie Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society* (London: SPCK; Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1989), 227. The full quotation is 'the only hermeneutic of the gospel ... a congregation of men and women who believe it and live by it.'